DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Did God Create the World?

Daat Tevunot §16-18

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §16-18 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 12 September 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we left off

Before tackling God's rule of the world and the questions about the end of days, the Sekhel first established why we are here: God wants human beings to complete themselves, to perfect themselves "with the sweat of our brow and the toil of our hands," and that perfection is itself the reward. We are not paid for misvot; by doing them we build our identity and become better people, able to enjoy the true perfection, which is God Himself. The Neshamah then asked: why does God want this?

A prior question (§16-17)

The Sekhel answers with a question. Before asking why God wants us to perfect ourselves, ask why He wanted to create creatures at all. Once humans exist, it makes sense that He wants them to perfect themselves; but why create them in the first place?

The Neshamah replies with an Aramaic phrase, "milta deshavya letarvayhu": give me one answer that settles both questions. Why did God create us at all, and why does He want us to perfect ourselves?

Goodness wants to give (§18)

The Sekhel's answer, which the group had also learnt in Derech Hashem: as far as we can grasp, God is the ultimate good, and the nature of the good is to do good to others. Someone who is perfectly good will want that goodness to spread. So God wanted to create beings in order to do good to them, since if there is no one to receive the good, there is no doing of good.

The Rabbi's illustration: I can tell you all day long what a good person I am, but if you never see my goodness in action you will never know. More than that, if I have been good for fifty years but now have no one to be good to, can I still be called good in ten years' time? Goodness that is only theoretical is not yet goodness.

Why we have to earn it

The Ramhal continues: for the good to be complete, God in His wisdom knew it was fitting that those receiving it should acquire it through their own effort. Then they are the owners of the good, and they will not be left with "boshet panim," shame, when they receive it.

The Rabbi explained shame through the saying of the Hakhamim that one who eats what is not his own is embarrassed to look at the face of the one who feeds him. Receiving charity is good, but being always on the receiving end is uncomfortable, because people want relationships to be balanced: - Someone gives you a present; you say thank you or give one back. - Someone harms you; he is now above you. One way to rebalance is revenge, which is why revenge feels sweet. The harder way, the way of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, is to forgive when he says sorry, because his apology brings him back down to your level.

So both questions are answered together. God created us to do good to us. He does not simply hand us the good, because good that is given is like living on charity. He gives us the potential for good, and we have to work to acquire it and make it our own.

What is the good? And why free will?

Asked what this good actually is, the group answered: God. God is the ultimate good, and since God cannot create other gods, the best good He can give is to let us connect to Him. The closer we are, the more intense the pleasure. That connection is olam haba.

Then why not create us already connected, with no world, no good and evil, no choice? The Rabbi's answer: that system would have worked, but it would be second best. Good that is handed to you is extrinsic. Hashem's goodness is intrinsic. When you have worked for it and chosen it, it becomes your own. To choose good, there has to be good and bad to choose between, so free will is the next step that follows from this, not the starting point.

Adam and the first test

A participant asked: could this not have been achieved with one misvah rather than 613? The Rabbi said that was indeed the original plan with Adam. The test was whether he would see everything as coming from God, or see other powers: a tree separate from God, the idea that one can be on a par with Him. That was a denial of yihud Hashem. Had Adam chosen well, he would have perfected himself and, as the Hakhamim say, that would have been olam haba. He fell, the world was corrupted, and now we have to work to rectify it, a process that is taking a long time.

He added that in Bereshit the first man is called "HaAdam," the man, not simply "Adam." HaAdam is humanity. Exactly how it worked we do not know, but it is more than one individual.

The question to think about

The Rabbi ended with a question that, he said, shows whether you have understood everything so far. If the problem with being handed the good is shame, why not create beings who have no shame? We feel shame because that is how we were created, but God could create a different creature, or billions of malakhim, who simply bask in His light for eternity

without embarrassment. Why insist on human beings and free choice? He left the group to think it over until the next class: "These are the foundations. We have to get these clear."

Summary

- Before asking why God wants us to perfect ourselves, the Sekhel asks why He created anything at all; the Neshamah wants one answer to both.
- God is the ultimate good, and the nature of the good is to give. He created beings so that He could do good to them.
- Good received without effort brings boshet panim. God gives the potential for good so that we acquire it ourselves and own it.
- The greatest good is connection with God himself; earning it requires choice, so good and evil and free will follow.
- Open question for next time: why not create beings without shame who receive the good freely?

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